MUSIC

Breaking Boundaries

Taba Chake, the indie singer-songwriter from Arunachal Pradesh, has made his Bollywood debut as a composer with **Shoojit Sircar**'s *I Want to Talk*



When it was time for Taba Chake to pick the album cover for *Bombay Dreams* (2019), his debut full-length album, the young Arunachali singer knew he wanted his face on it. "At the time, I was inundated with questions about how I speak such good Hindi, which was very tiring," says the 31-year-old. The 10-track set with songs in English, Hindi and Nyishi (Chake's native language) has, as per his official YouTube channel, racked up over 55 million streams across all music platforms. The serene folksy sound of tracks like 'Shaayad' and 'Aao Chalein' found favour among reel creators and helped to cement his Hindi-speaking credentials. "I feel accomplished for having made people aware that we Arunachalis or other Northeasterners can and do speak Hindi," he says with a laugh, adding, "Thankfully, no one asks me this question anymore."

Chake has taken another big step towards the mainstream this month with the release of his debut film as a composer, lyrist and singer, Shoojit Sircar's Abhishek Bachchan-starrer *I Want to Talk*. "I couldn't believe it when I was initially called by one of the film's producers, Ronnie Lahiri to meet Shoojit sir. I was very curious as to why they had approached me and they said it's because my songs are mature and philosophical and that's what the film needed."

I Want to Talk revolves around a man dealing with a life-threatening disease while also trying to repair his relationships. "Shoojit sir gave me a very detailed narration in our first meeting. After that, every time I'd start work on a new song, he'd talk me through the situation." Chake describes the experience as both exhilarating and stressful. "My beard turned completely grey in the eight months that I worked on this film, but it was worth it. A few years ago, I had actually moved to Mumbai because I wanted to compose music for films, but I found myself doing everything else to earn rent money." He now splits his time between Mumbai and Doimukh, his village on the outskirts of Itanagar.

The singer-songwriter's brush with music started in boarding school. "I must have been in Class 4 when I first heard a classmate play Bryan Adams's *Summer of '69* on his acoustic guitar. I had goosebumps and fell in love with the sound of the guitar. Until then, I had no interest in or understanding of music, even though we had regular music lessons in school." Chake was so obsessed with the instrument that he'd pester his friend to teach him every night after lights-out in the hostel. "It was then that I knew I wanted to make music for the rest of my life."

Having lived all of their lives in Doimukh, Chake's parents weren't wondering 'if there is money to be made in music' but had an even more basic question—'how can music be a career?' "This was before we had cafés

Taba's 2019 album **BOMBAY DREAMS** racked up over 55 million streams across all music platforms